What a reward model can show depends on who stopped the episode: failure judges and monitors on a low-cost arm

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Abstract

Reward models that score robot rollouts are also used as failure detectors. We compared two zero-shot reward models with plain episode length. On ArmnetBench, a public SO-101 benchmark where runs end at a time limit, length separates failure from success at AUROC 0.942 within policy. Failed runs are slow rather than cut off. Length observed only up to half of the longest episode still gives 0.851. Both reward models score below length, the better one at 0.821. On our own rollouts an operator stopped each run by judgment. There length falls to 0.56, and neither reward model beats the identity of the policy. A judge that sees the finished episode passes its threshold, at an operating point chosen in-sample. No mid-episode monitor reaches its bar. The baseline a detector has to beat depends on the dataset's stopping rule.

1 Introduction

Papers that evaluate a reward model as a failure detector normally compare it with other learned detectors. When a benchmark stops failed runs at a time limit, the length of an episode also encodes its outcome. The identity of the policy that ran can carry it too, and we call this the policy-identity null (mainly with models that give out-of-distribution results). When the operator stops each run by his judgment, both signals are weaker. We call the way a dataset ends its episodes its stopping rule. None of the reward-model papers in our library reports the stopping rule or a length baseline.

We started with a narrower claim, that elapsed time is the reward model to beat. Our own rollouts did not support it. On them length is near chance, and a robot-trained judge passed its pre-registered threshold. The stopping rule separates the two results, so it became the subject of the paper.

*Code, result files and the checks that regenerate every number: `github.com/ravediamond/paper-reward-models-stopping-rule`. The frozen protocols are copied verbatim under `repro/`; the bar commits named in the paper belong to the authors' research repository `ravediamond/road-to-robotics`.

We measured length on ArmnetBench [12] and on our own rollouts. The length analyses were frozen before any number existed. We compared length with two zero-shot reward models, Robometer [5] and TOPReward [1]. On our 88 operator-stopped rollouts we also compared it with every judge and monitor we had run.

2 Data and labels

ArmnetBench v0.1 [12] has 8 tasks and 7 policies on the SO-101. We use its 2,047 policy rollouts with a success or failure class (515 successes, 1,532 failures). We leave out the teleoperated episodes. One task, pushing a Displayport cable (270 rollouts), has rollouts of a single class and so no per-task AUROC. Our own data are 88 labelled bowls-task episodes on one SO-101 arm with a Jetson Orin NX. Every monitor gate used the same 50-episode subset (42 successes, 8 failures). The author was the operator. He stopped each run and labelled it at rest, not blind to the policy.

3 The length baseline

On ArmnetBench, episode length is a strong failure detector within each policy (Table 1, Fig. 1). Pooled over policies it reaches 0.938. Within each policy it ranges from 0.91 to 0.96. Pair-weighted, the within-policy value is 0.942, with a CI of 0.927–0.956.

The within-policy value pair-weights the per-policy AUROCs (`repro/length-null/scripts/length_analysis.py`):

```
def stratified(df, score, by="policy_type"):
    """Pair-weighted mean of per-stratum AUROCs (weights successes
      x failures)."""
    num = den = 0.0
    for _, g in df.groupby(by):
        a = auroc(g.y, g[score]); w = g.y.sum() * (~g.y).sum()
        if a is not None:
            num += a * w; den += w
    return num / den if den else None
```

We ran Robometer-4B [5] zero-shot, as its authors ship it. It scores 0.818 pooled and 0.821 within policy. The within-policy value is pair-weighted over its per-policy scores, and their range stands in for a CI (§7). We ran

signal	pooled	within policy
episode length	0.938 (0.925–0.951)	0.942 (0.927–0.956)
length seen up to 50 % of the longest run	—	0.851 (0.829–0.873)
Robometer-4B, success probability	0.818 (0.790–0.843)	0.821 (per-policy 0.79–0.87)
Robometer-4B, last progress (descriptive)	0.838 (no CI)	—
TOPReward, success score	0.653 (0.623–0.684)	0.661 (0.631–0.692)
TOPReward, Yes/No component (descriptive)	—	0.678

Table 1: ArmnetBench, failure AUROC with 95 % episode-bootstrap CIs. Read down the within-policy column: no reward-model score reaches length.

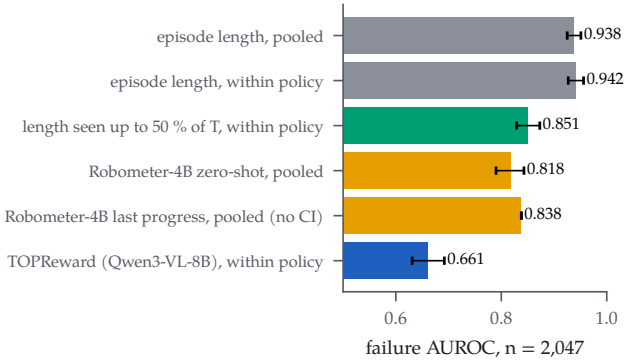


Figure 1: Failure AUROC on ArmnetBench: episode length against two zero-shot reward models. Length leads both, pooled and within policy (95 % CIs where available).

TOPReward [1] with Qwen3-VL-8B [11] and no training. It scores 0.661 within policy. Its paired difference to length has a 95 % CI of -0.31 to -0.25. The protocols fixed each model's primary score before any score existed. For Robometer it is the success probability, and for TOPReward the success score of its paper. Two other scores from the same runs are in Table 1 as descriptive rows. They are higher, and still below length.

4 Length is more than the timeout

We take each task's longest episode as its timeout. Only 8.7 % of failures run that long. At half that length, 88 % of failures are still running. Only 19 % of successes are. Length observed up to that cut gives 0.851 within policy (CI 0.829–0.873; Fig. 2). TOPReward on frames up to the same cut reaches 0.667. Failed rollouts are slow, not timed out. Both readings fixed in the protocol hold.

On our own operator-stopped rollouts, length is at chance. It gives 0.56 on the 69 rollouts TOPReward scored and 0.52 on all 88. Here the policy-identity null is the baseline to beat. 17 of the 25 failures in the 69 come from one policy, TurboVLA [16]. Neither reward model beats policy identity. TOPReward scores 0.82 (CI 0.70–0.93), and policy identity alone 0.87. On the 50 episodes without TurboVLA, TOPReward scores 0.78. Robometer scores 0.577 on all 88, and policy identity 0.878.

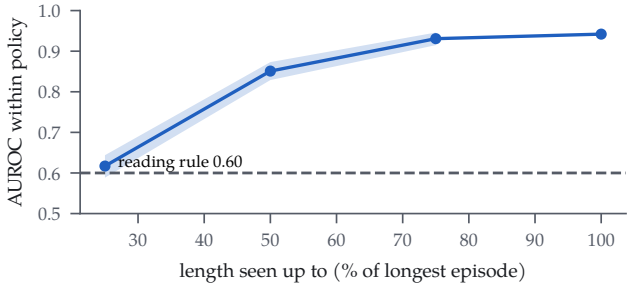


Figure 2: Length observed up to a fraction of the task's longest episode, AUROC within policy: most of the signal is there by half the episode (band: 95 % CI).

5 Judges and monitors on our rollouts

Table 2 gives each judge and monitor a threshold-free AUROC where one is defined. It also gives failures caught and successes flagged at the operating point. For the judges at rest, that point is chosen in-sample.

We first ran a deterministic top-camera check (colour masks and geometry, no learning). It is right on 94.3 % of judged episodes. It has 0 false positives (Wilson 0–13 then gave Flora-Rewarder-27B [8] a 64-frame two-view clip and NVIDIA's prompt. It reaches a threshold-free AUROC of 1.00 (bootstrap CI 1.00–1.00). At its in-sample operating point it flags 8 of 8 failures at 2 of 42 successes (Wilson on the false alarms 1–16 at least 6 of 8 failures at no more than 2 of 42 successes, so it passes. Its base model, Qwen3.5-27B [10], has no robot fine-tune. On the same input it also passes, with AUROC 0.91 (0.78–1.00) and 7 of 8 at 2 of 42. The input format mattered more than the fine-tune. Qwen3.5-9B [10] flags 16 successes and fails. Gemini 3.8 Flash [2] fails by one false alarm.

The bar for mid-episode monitors is at least 5 of 8 failures at no more than 1 of 20 false interventions. No monitor reaches it on these 50 rollouts (Fig. 3). The surprise of a separate world model, trained in the LeWorldModel recipe [7], catches 2 of 8 at 2 of 42 (AUROC 0.86). A Gemini sliding-window judge catches 0. We also built an action-conditioned risk head on the world model's latent. Its first version reached AUROC 0.93. It read elapsed time, so we withdrew that result. We pre-registered a second version without time or length. It catches 3 of 8 at 5 of 42. Its AUROC is 0.79, and 0.71 with shuffled actions. The MLP variant catches 6 of 8 and flags 13 of 42.

method	kind	AUROC	caught / 8	flagged / 42	threshold
colour judge (no learning)	at rest	— (94.3 % right, 0 FP, 5 FN)	—	—	fixed rule
Flora-Rewarder-27B	at rest	1.00 (1.00–1.00)	8	2	in-sample
Qwen3.5-27B, same input	at rest	0.91 (0.78–1.00)	7	2	in-sample
Qwen3.5-9B, same input	at rest	0.75	7	16	in-sample
Gemini 3.8 Flash, same input	at rest	0.96	8	3	in-sample
Gemini sliding windows	monitor	—	0	1	fixed before scoring
world-model surprise	monitor	0.86	2	2	fixed before scoring
world-model latent drift	monitor	0.30	0	2	fixed before scoring
risk head, logistic (v2)	monitor	0.79	3	5	5-fold by episode
risk head, MLP (v2)	monitor	—	6	13	5-fold by episode

Table 2: Judges and monitors on the 50 operator-stopped rollouts (42 successes, 8 failures). Judges see the finished episode; monitors are held to $\geq 5/8$ caught at $\leq 1/20$ false interventions.

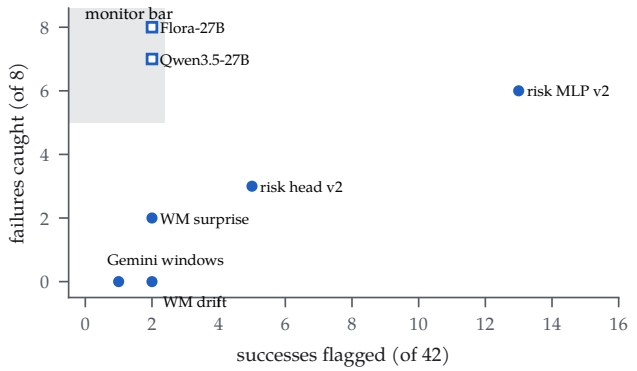


Figure 3: Failures caught against successes flagged on the 50 rollouts. No monitor (circles) reaches its shaded bar; the judges at rest (squares) sit at their in-sample operating point, where the monitor bar does not apply.

6 Related work

Robometer [5] scales a general-purpose reward model through trajectory comparisons. TOPReward [1] reads the token probabilities of a video-language model as hidden rewards. A survey of verifiers for robot policies [14] covers the wider family. FAIL-Detect [17] and SAFE [3] learn uncertainty- and feature-based failure scores for imitation and VLA policies. FARM [9] reads failure signals from the internal states of a frozen world model, like our world-model monitors. ReAP [6] predicts action-conditioned risk, and our risk head follows it. VLA-Corrector [13] verifies stages, Spotter [4] adds a reflecting VLM, and REMORA [15] tracks progress through errors and recovery. ArmnetBench [12] and a standardized SO-101 VLA benchmark [18] evaluate policies on the same arm. None of these works reports the elapsed-length baseline under the dataset's stopping rule.

7 Limitations

The judge pass on our own rollouts rests on 8 failures. Its operating thresholds were chosen on the same 50 episodes. A single operator, the author, labelled them and was not blind to the policy. The threshold-free AUROCs do not depend on the threshold. Fresh rollouts scored at the frozen thresholds would confirm the operating points. 17 of the 25 failures in our 69 rollouts are TurboVLA's. Any score that reads the policy therefore gets the policy-identity null for free. The risk head is trained and tested on the same 50 episodes. Five folds by episode keep episodes from leaking, but tasks and policies leak. Robometer's per-episode scores stayed on an older machine. Its within-policy number therefore has no episode-bootstrap CI, and it is missing from the truncation analysis. A copy from that machine or a re-score of about $6 would restore both. TOPReward's paper does not give its prefix count, frames per query or Yes/No wording, so those are our choices. The ArmnetBench result covers eight tasks. The timeout is approximated by each task's longest episode.

8 Conclusion

On ArmnetBench, where runs end at a time limit, episode length beat both reward models. On our operator-stopped rollouts length was at chance, and a judge that saw the whole finished episode caught the failures. When you evaluate a reward model as a failure detector, report episode length within policy on the same rows and say how the episodes ended.

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analysis	repro folder	expected files	protocol
length baseline, truncation	repro/length-null	length_armnetbench.json, counts_ci.json	LENGTH_PROTOCOL.md, frozen `1a69f30`
Robometer on ArmnetBench	repro/robometer-judge	g9a_ab_complete.json	PROTOCOL.md (primary score fixed there)
Robometer and length on own rollouts	repro/robometer-judge	g9a_own.json	PROTOCOL.md
colour judge	repro/robometer-judge	g9c3_test_results.json	PROTOCOL.md
TOPReward, both datasets	repro/topreward	topreward.json, own_rollout_labels.csv	TOPREWARD_PROTOCOL.md, `6241570`
judges at rest, input-format gate	repro/flora-input-format	g_flora_summary.json, g_flora_abl_summary.json	PROTOCOL.md
window judge, world-model monitors	repro/six-monitors	judge_tau.json, w1a_summary.json	PROTOCOL.md
action-conditioned risk head	repro/reap	monitors.json, monitors_v2.json	PROTOCOL.md

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Appendix: from plain name to analysis

Every number is recomputable from the repository; this table maps each analysis to its files.